thousands of nonbreeding worker bees ensure the reproduction of the genes they have in common with the sole breeding individual, the queen.

Critics of Dawkins' theory argue that since individual genes do not control behavior, they cannot be said to be acting selfishly. Dawkins has maintained that he never meant to suggest that genes had their own conscious will. He later wrote that "the immortal gene" might have been a better title for both his concept and the book.



A male black widow spider gingerly approaches a huge female to mate. This genetically driven act will reproduce his genes but will lead to his death.